



The Real Cost of What We Throw Away

How the food we waste harms the planet, our wallets, and our neighbors.



The Problem

About a third of all the food grown for people around the world never gets eaten. In the United States, close to 30 to 40 percent of the food supply is thrown out. Most of that waste starts in our own kitchens, along with restaurants, grocery stores, and farms.

1/3

of all food made worldwide is wasted every year

30–40%

of the U.S. food supply is never eaten

#1

source of food waste is our own homes



Why It Matters



Environment

8–10%

of the world's greenhouse gas emissions come from wasted food. In landfills it gives off methane, a gas far stronger than carbon dioxide, and it wastes the water, land, and fuel used to grow it.



Economy

\$218B

worth of food is thrown away in the U.S. every year. That comes to about \$1,500 for the average family of four that ends up straight in the trash.



Society

34M

Americans, including millions of children, struggle to get enough to eat, even while good, edible food is being thrown out every single day.



Top Solutions

1



Rescue and donate surplus food

Connect grocery stores, restaurants, and farms with food banks so extra food feeds people instead of filling landfills.

2



Community and home composting

Turn food scraps into healthy soil through curbside pickup and backyard bins instead of sending them to the dump.

3



Smart shopping and clear date labels

Help people plan meals, buy what they need, and read labels correctly so they stop tossing food that is still good.



Rating the Top 3 on the Three E's

Each solution weighed against the three pillars of sustainability: Environment, Economy, and Equity.

Top Solution	Environment	Economy	Equity
Rescue & donate surplus food	HIGH Keeps edible food out of landfills and cuts methane.	MED Transport and storage cost money, but donor tax breaks help.	HIGH Feeds people facing hunger right away.
Community & home composting	HIGH Cuts landfill methane and rebuilds healthy soil.	MED Startup and pickup costs, but creates jobs and usable compost.	MED Greens neighborhoods, but does not feed people directly.
Smart shopping & clear labels	HIGH Stops waste at the source, where most of it starts.	HIGH Costs little to run and saves families money.	MED Helps households save, but reaches people unevenly.

HIGH = strong benefit **MED** = some trade-offs